dashed VOC's hopes of the steamers beginning their service in mid-January 1907.[67]

*Bande Mataram*'s correspondent from Tirunelveli—probably C. Thambusami Pillai—while confirming the purchase, reported in late February that while the *Gallia* was at Marseilles booking passengers and expecting to begin operations soon, the *Lawoe* was in England receiving cargo.[68] The report added for good measure—no doubt to pep up the Swadeshi mood—that the purchase of the steamers by SSNCo was creating 'a panic in the minds of the British India Steam Navigation Co'.[69] The *Gallia* (with W.W. Chapman as captain) had set sail from Marseilles on 22 March. Four days later it arrived at Port Said, sailing to Aden on 3 April.[70]

In late March, VOC wired to *The Hindu* that the two steamers and the steam launches had passed Port Said and were approaching Bombay: while the *Lawoe* was expected on 3 April, the *Gallia* was to arrive four days later, on 7 April; the two steam launches would reach Colombo on 8 April.[71] Talking to a Tuticorin police inspector on 31 March, immediately on his return from Bombay, VOC said that although the two steamers would reach Bombay in a week, they were expected in Tuticorin only in the middle of April. He might have been economical with the truth as he was talking to a police inspector.[72] On the very day of his arrival in Tuticorin, he proceeded to Tirunelveli where he gave back-to-back lectures—on 31 March and 1 April—at the Nellaiyappar Temple mandapam and at Lala Chatram.[73] After these two public talks he suddenly proceeded to Madurai en route to Bombay again. His rushed return to Bombay was not without reason: as he told *Bande Mataram*'s correspondent in Madurai, the ships had arrived in Bombay, and he was making a dash to receive them.[74] On 4 April 1907, VOC was in Bombay to receive the steamers.[75] The Swadeshi dream had fructified.

By 'a strange coincidence', according to *Bande Mataram*, both the *Lawoe* and the *Gallia* were lying in Bombay harbour. The *Lawoe* had arrived from Birkenhead, Liverpool on 2 April while the *Gallia*, having sailed from Marseilles on the 10th, had reached Bombay at about the same